

By M.G. Radhakrishnan

The Opposition United Democratic Front (UDF) in Kerala is famous for snatching defeat from the jaws of victory. With Assembly elections barely a year away and constituents of the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) deserting the coalition like rats leaving a sinking ship, victory for the UDF in the coming polls seemed a foregone conclusion. Last week the LDF was engulfed in yet another crisis when the Kerala Congress (KC) became the fourth constituent to quit and cross over to the UDF in the last four years. It should have been occasion to pass around *laddoos* at Indira Bhavan, the Congress headquarters in Thiruvananthapuram. Instead, there is gloom, mutual recriminations and apprehensions.

There's much mudslinging in the UDF after P.J Joseph, founder of KC and a constituent of the LDF for over two decades, resigned from the Cabinet, quit the LDF and decided to merge with the Kerala Congress-Mani (KC-M), another Christian-dominated party named after its leader, K.M. Mani. The



Mergers and ACCUSATIONS

Next year's Assembly elections were expected to be a cakewalk for the Congress-led UDF but LDF deserters have sparked a war within

Congress and other UDF parties have opposed Joseph's entry into the UDF, saying both the minister and his party would be a handicap that would damage the Front's prospects. But Mani, who leads the third largest UDF constituent, has said the Congress had no business opposing the merger. The Congress has asked the KC-M to leave

the UDF than bring Joseph into the Front but its veteran chairman retorted that he would go it alone.

Three Christian parties—there is also a KC (Jacob)—hold considerable sway in vast tracts of central Kerala dominated by the community. As senior leaders on both sides spewed venom against each other, their

student and youth wings took to street fights. "For four years, we campaigned against the misdeeds of Joseph and his party. His inclusion in the UDF in the final year of the LDF rule will cause public apathy," said Oommen Chandy, Opposition leader and Congress strongman. Mani shot back: "The Congress has no business